

# Session 27: People as Gifts in Ephesians 4

## Key Takeaways

- Leaders of the Church are not appointed based on the Greco-Roman categories of worth and honor. Rather, their ability to lead is a gift given in grace, and their purpose is to build up God’s people so they can be Christ’s body in the world.

## Spiritual Gifts in the New Testament

In [Ephesians 4:11-12](#), the gifts are leaders whose abilities sustain and guide the unity of God’s people. They “build up” (a temple metaphor) God’s people so they can do the work (recall [Eph. 2:10](#)) of service.

Paul reshapes the very concept of leadership and influence in contrast to the Greco-Roman systems of honor and status. Those who lead in the messianic body are not installed on the basis of traditional categories of worth/honor. Rather, even their ability to lead (as apostles, evangelists, teachers, etc.) is a gift that they did not earn but were given in God’s mercy.

“Every believer is to reckon himself or herself dependent upon the single gift of divine mercy: Believers cannot boast as if there were something about themselves that rendered them worthy of the divine call. Re-grounded in the mercy of God, they are able to perceive their differentiated roles within the believer-community as divinely distributed gifts. Just as Paul’s authority to instruct as an apostle is a product of 'grace/gift' (χάρις), so each of them has a 'gift' (δῶσις) given to them ... Within this community, honor does not have to be sought: All the honor that counts has already been given, or will be given by God. Freed from the need to establish their honor in competition ... believers can afford to grant it to others.”

Barclay, John M. G. (2015). [Paul and the Gift](#). Eerdmans. 510.

| Verse                                                                                                         | Spiritual Gifts                                                         | Reference                                                                                                                                                                           |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Romans 12:6–8                                                                                                 | 1. Prophecy<br>2. Serving<br>3. Teaching<br>4. Exhortation<br>5. Giving | Romans 12:5-6: “Thus we the many are one body in Messiah, and each one is a member of another. And having graces/gifts (χαρίσματα) according the grace/gift which was given to us.” |
| List of Spiritual Gifts in New Testament. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019). |                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                     |

| Verse                                                                                                                | Spiritual Gifts                                                                                                                                                                                | Reference                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                                      | 6. Leadership<br>7. Mercy                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 1 Corinthians 12:8–10                                                                                                | 1. Word of wisdom<br>2. Word of knowledge<br>3. Faith<br>4. Gifts of healings<br>5. Miracles<br>6. Prophecy<br>7. Distinguishing between spirits<br>8. Tongues<br>9. Interpretation of tongues | 1 Corinthians 12:4, 7, 12: “Varieties of gifts/graces (χαρισμάτων), but the same Spirit ... but to each one was given the revealing of the Spirit for the common good. ... Just as the body is one, and has many members, but all the members of the body, though being many, are one body, so also it is with the Messiah.” |
| 1 Corinthians 12:28                                                                                                  | 1. Apostle<br>2. Prophet<br>3. Teacher<br>4. Miracles<br>5. Kinds of healings<br>6. Helps<br>7. Administration<br>8. Tongues                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Ephesians 4:11                                                                                                       | 1. Apostle<br>2. Prophet<br>3. Evangelist<br>4. Pastor<br>5. Teacher                                                                                                                           | Ephesians 4:7: “And to each one of us grace/gift (χαρις) was given, according to the measure of the generous gift of the Messiah.”                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| 1 Peter 4:11                                                                                                         | 1. Whoever speaks<br>2. Whoever renders service                                                                                                                                                | 1 Peter 4:10: “Each one, just as he has received a grace/gift (χαρισμα), using it to serve one another, as good stewards of the diversified grace (χαριτος) of God.”                                                                                                                                                         |
| <i>List of Spiritual Gifts in New Testament.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019). |                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

## Definitions of Spiritual Gifts in New Testament

### Apostle

Apostle, when capitalized, means those who saw the risen Jesus and were commissioned by him. This word is used to refer to the twelve disciples (Matt. 10:2, Mark 3:14) and the others who saw Jesus, like James ([Gal. 1:19](#))

and Paul (Gal. 1:1).

In general use, an apostle is a passionate initiator of spreading the good news and leading new efforts of church planting and building in new centers of ministry. It is used to refer to leaders in the early Jesus movement who helped initiate new ministry projects, like Andronicus and Junia (Rom. 16:7) and Barnabas (Acts 14:14).

## Prophet

Prophets are people steeped in the Scriptures and in the nuances of the present cultural moment, who can discern the will of God for specific people/communities and address them with authority.

In 1 Corinthians 14, Paul does not describe prophecy as “ecstatic speech.” Rather, the prophet has control of their faculties (14:32), and prophecy engages the mind (14:15, 19). It requires thought and mental engagement. This does not seem like ecstatic speech. It’s equated with instruction (*katekheisis*, 14:19), and it helps people learn (*manthano*, 14:31) and be encouraged (*parakaleo*, 14:31).

“Prophesying in Paul’s theology is the performing of intelligible, articulate speech acts which depend on the active agency of the Holy Spirit mediated through human minds and lives to build up, encourage, exhort, and comfort others in the context of interpersonal relations.”

Thistlethorn, Anthony C. (2013). [\*The First Epistle to the Corinthians \(The New International Greek Testament Commentary\)\*](#). Eerdmans. 1 Cor 14:2.

## Evangelist

Someone who is able to share the good news about Jesus in a uniquely effective way.

The noun is used only to describe Philip of Caesarea (Acts 21:8) and Timothy (2 Tim. 4:5), but the verb is simply “to announce good news,” which widens the reference considerably.

## Pastor

Pastor literally means “shepherd,” someone who cares about and can effectively guide the spiritual growth of a community of disciples.

Jesus is described as the “head pastor” of the universal church (1 Pet. 2:25, 5:4). The noun is used only here, whereas the verb is used of church leaders “to shepherd” (1 Pet. 5:2; Acts 20:28). In the New Testament, this refers to an activity, not the title of an office.

## Teacher

A teacher is someone with growing knowledge of the Scriptures and the story of Jesus, who is able to explain and help people adopt a Christian imagination and its corresponding lifestyle.

Teachers are listed after apostles and prophets in 1 Corinthians 12:28. Their role seems to be connected to the passing on and explication of doctrines and traditions of the church (cf. Rom. 6:17; 1 Cor. 4:17; Col. 2:7).

Teachers appear to be central in the growth in wisdom and knowledge that Paul desires for the Ephesians in 1:17–19 and 3:18–19. (For more, see Stephen E. Fowl, [Ephesians: A Commentary](#), 141.)

## Reflection Question

According to “the powers,” giftedness would be something to pursue and bolster in order to receive personal honor. But Paul has a different view of spiritual gifts. According to Paul, what is the purpose of the gifts in Ephesians 4?